TRAVELLING FEAST



Travelling across India, chef Thomas Zacharias has sampled cuisines from almost all the states. Here, he talks about some of his favourites

By Joanna Lobo



It was the summer of 2013. Thomas Zacharias was on an adventure: a four-month tour of France, Italy and Spain. He ate, drank and worked his way through 36 town and cities. This was his first Chef on the Road (COTR) journey.

After returning to India, a restless Zacharias decided he needed to embark on something similar here. He had just been signed on as chef for The Bombay Canteen (TBC) and wanted to highlight unknown Indian fare. Five months later, he began his first culinary trip across India. "It blew my mind, learning the depth and nuances of Indian food," he says. Thus began the Indian edition of COTR, one that continues to this day.

For eight years, Zacharias has been exploring India, focusing on the different regions, meeting locals and food experts, going to markets, learning artisanal and traditional recipes and visiting farms and producers to get a deeper understanding of Indian cuisine in a more authentic way. Back then, the idea was to take inspiration and create his own interpretation of the food for the TBC menu. Today, having left TBC, he wants to focus on making a deeper intervention in the Indian food system and galvanise a movement around it.

Zacharias makes copious notes of his trips; he has about 146,000 photos and videos. These days, he travels with a team that visually documents his experiences. The chef hopes to turn all their footage into a TV series someday. Here, we got him to pick ten memorable dishes and meals from COTR—chosen from different parts of the country, with a healthy combination of meat, veggies and desserts. Think of it as a COTR menu.